brotherhood and later mythologised it in his own mind). It is, however, almost certain that he did not belong to the inner circle of resistance, though he did provide ‘political and moral solidarity’ by helping comrades keep up the fighting spirit. Because of his job as a doctor’s orderly, he slipped extra provisions to sick inmates and facilitated illegal meetings.

We arranged things like telling some prisoners they should report ill. Then we locked them in the waiting cell and conducted them to the doctor. In that way, we created a possibility for some comrades to discuss things with each other.

3

Fellow inmate, Max Frenzel, vouched for Honecker’s underground work, saying he was ‘always the comrade who did his duty in these difficult years in this hostile environment, despite Nazi terror and daily threats’.4 Likewise, Wilhelm Thiele, sentenced to life imprisonment, found himself temporarily in a cell with Honecker. ‘When comrades spend the difficult times of their lives confined together in a tiny cell for years, they not only get to know each other inside and out, but a close feeling of togetherness also develops. Erich was animated by an unshakable optimism, he radiated friendliness.’5 Good news from the outside world was scant. Honecker was saddened to learn his brother, Robert, was dispatched with the newly formed Afrika Korps to shore up the Italian effort in the Middle East in March 1941. Robert endured a difficult time in North Africa and Greece, where he eventually became ill and was taken prisoner.

However, a morale booster came a few months later when Germany invaded the Soviet Union on Sunday, 22 June, ending the much-hated Molotov–Ribbentrop pact, which had allied the Nazis with Stalin.

Honecker suffered from intense homesickness and often treated cellmates to imaginary tours of Wiebelskirchen. He found distraction by devouring the